

BRAND & STYLE GUIDE · V1.0

Subhra Sekhar.

An editorial, engineering-first identity system. Calm warm paper, deep navy, a single warm accent. Serif display for craft, sans for clarity, mono for technical signal.

DISCIPLINE

Independent Software Engineer

AESTHETIC

Editorial · Technical · Warm

ISSUED

May 2026

Brand Principles

Four ideas govern every visual and verbal decision. When in doubt, choose the option that more strongly expresses one of these — and never one that contradicts another.

Editorial, not corporate

Design like a thoughtful publication, not a SaaS landing page. Generous whitespace, considered typography, content-first hierarchy.

Engineering signal

Monospaced labels and reference numbers (§01, SSM-2026-014) communicate precision. The system is built, not decorated.

Warm, not cold

Paper background, warm accent, off-white type on navy — never pure white on black. Calm, confident, human.

Restraint

One serif, one sans, one mono. One navy, one accent. No gradients. No emoji. No iconography unless functional.

Logo & Wordmark



Clear space

Reserve clear space equal to the cap-height of the wordmark on every side. The mark and wordmark sit on a shared baseline with a 14px gap between them.

Minimum size

Wordmark: 18px / 14pt. Mark alone: 24px square. Below this, legibility breaks down — use the mark alone or the wordmark, never both, at small sizes.

SECTION 03

§ 03

Color System

Two anchors (Navy, Paper), one warm accent, and a small neutral set. The accent is rare — used for kickers, section numbers, and small emphasis only. Never as a primary surface.

Aa Navy #12263A Primary surface · headings on paper	Aa Navy 2 #1B3553 Hover · alt navy surface	Aa Ink #0E1A28 Body text · borders	Aa Accent #B8895A Kickers · § marks · rules
Aa Paper #F7F3EC Page background	Aa Paper 2 #EFE9DE Card surface	Aa Line #C9BFAE Hairlines · dividers	Aa Muted #6B6456 Captions · meta · labels

Pairing rules Navy + Paper is the canonical pairing. Accent appears only on small marks — never as a fill on areas larger than a button. Ink for body type on Paper. Paper for body type on Navy.	What's banned No gradients. No drop shadows on type. No pure black (#000) or pure white (#fff) — always warm. No additional accent hues; if you need a second signal, use weight or scale instead.
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Typography

DISPLAY · FRAUNCES
SERIF

Aa

Headlines, display, section titles, callout numbers. Optical sizing on. Weight 500 default.

BODY · SANS INTER

Aa

Body, UI, paragraphs, lists. Weights 300/400/500/600/700. Body at 14.5–15px.

TECHNICAL · JETBRAINS
MONO MONO

Aa

Kickers, labels, references, code. Always uppercase with .14–.20em tracking when used as a label.

DISPLAY	Editorial design.	64 / 1.0 / 500
H1	Section title	44 / 1.05 / 500
H2	Subsection title	30 / 1.1 / 500
H3	Card heading	18 / 1.2 / 600
BODY	Body copy at 15px sets the rhythm for the system. Long-form paragraphs read calmly at this size; lists and cards step down to 13.5px.	15 / 1.6 / 400
CAPTION	Meta · captions · footnotes	12 / 1.5 / 400
KICKER	SECTION 04 · TYPOGRAPHY	11 / .2em / 400
REFERENCE	§04 · SSM-2026-014	11 / .16em / 500

Pairing

Fraunces for everything that says *this is a thought*. Inter for everything that says *this is a fact you can read*. JetBrains Mono for everything that says *this is a label or a reference*. Never mix display weight serif inside body copy.

Letter-spacing

Fraunces tracks tight: -0.015em on headings, -0.02em on display. Inter at 0. Mono at +0.14em → +0.20em when uppercased as a kicker. Tracking is part of the system, not optional.

Spacing & Layout

Spacing follows a 4px base. Most surfaces use 8 / 12 / 18 / 24 / 32 / 48 / 64. Print pages use 18mm margins. Web pages use 48px gutters at desktop, 24px at mobile.

space-1		4 px
space-2		8 px
space-3		12 px
space-4		18 px
space-5		24 px
space-6		32 px
space-7		48 px
space-8		64 px
space-9		96 px

Borders & rules

1px hairline in `--line` (#C9BFAE). 2px section accent in Navy. Dashed dividers (1px dashed line) for inside-list separators. **No** rounded corners — corners are square (border-radius: 0).

Grids

Two-column for paired content. Three-column for triplets (stats, options, cards). Four-column for swatches. Gutters: 14–18px. Avoid five+ column grids.

SECTION 06

§ 06

Components

Buttons

Primary action

Default

Ghost

Accent (rare)

Badges

DEFAULT

NAVY

ACCENT

Stat cards

EFFORT

136 h

17 working days

RATE

\$15 /h

USD · time & materials

ESTIMATE

\$2,040

USD · with risk buffer

Tables

#	ITEM	DETAIL	STATUS
01	Discovery & scoping	Read API docs, confirm credentials, map payloads.	Done
02	App skeleton	Create custom app, configure scopes, register webhooks.	In progress
03	Integration code	Deploy handlers to client server.	Queued

Lists

—

Lists use a 10px accent rule prefix instead of bullets.

—

Items separated by 1px dashed lines for rhythm.

—

Last item drops the bottom rule.

—

Body sits at 13.5px inside a card; 15px in a full-width context.

Voice & Copy

Direct, concrete, slightly editorial. Short sentences alongside one longer one. Confident without being cold. Technical terms used precisely — never as decoration.

DO

"Three calendar weeks from kickoff. The 48-hour estimate already includes QA and a 20% risk buffer."

DON'T

"We'll leverage cutting-edge solutions to deliver world-class results that delight stakeholders."

DO

"The app does only what it needs to — nothing more."

DON'T

"Our innovative platform empowers seamless end-to-end integration capabilities."

Sentence rhythm

Mix short and long. A short declarative followed by one with a clause. Avoid three medium sentences in a row — it reads flat.

Numbers & units

Always specific: "136 h", "17 working days", "\$2,040".
Never "a few weeks" or "around \$2k". Specificity is the voice.

Em dashes

Used liberally to qualify a statement — like this. Set with spaces around them. They're part of the editorial tone.

In Use



Subhra Sekhar

WORK WRITING ABOUT CONTACT →

INDEPENDENT ENGINEER • AVAILABLE MAY 2026

Engineering, written like a publication.

Shopify integrations, custom backends, and the occasional rescue project. Based in India, working across time zones. Currently shipping a Bar-Call Haaretz integration.

View work

Read writing

ESSAY • 2026

Why I stopped charging fixed-price.

Fixed-price hides risk. Time-and-materials, with a transparent hour log, is fairer to both sides — and forces the conversations a project actually needs.

READ • 6 MIN

CASE STUDY • SHOPIFY

Bar-Call Haaretz Integration

A private Shopify app and middleware deployment that turned a manual fulfilment loop into an automated, observable pipeline — in 17 working days.

CASE • 4 MIN

Don't

DON'T

Use gradients on backgrounds, buttons, or text. The system is flat by design.

DON'T

Round corners. Buttons, cards, badges, images — all square.

DON'T

Use emoji as design elements. If a glyph is needed, use a typographic mark (·, →, \$).

DON'T

Introduce a third color hue. If you need contrast, change weight or size, not color.

DON'T

Use Inter or any sans for headlines. Headlines are always Fraunces.

DON'T

Mix paragraph copy in monospace. Mono is for labels, references, and inline code only.

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